

Overcalls

Because of the Defensive element, the most important requirement for an Overcall is that you have a good suit, one that you'd like partner to lead. Keep in mind:

- a 5-card or longer suit with honor strength

- 9-16 points to overcall at the 1-level

- 11-16 points to overcall at the 2-level

Takeout Doubles

There are three kinds of Takeout Double:

- opening hand strength, no more than 2 of opponent's suit, at least 3 in all other suits
- strong Overcall type, at least 17 points and a good suit. Double, then bid the suit.
- strong Notrump type, 19+ points, stopper in their suit. Double, then bid notrump.

Responding to a Takeout Double

- 0-8 points, bid your best suit as cheaply as possible

- 9-11 points, jump in your best suit

- 12 or more points, cue-bid the opponent's suit

Board: 1

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead:  J

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 1 

Declarer: East

Lead:  9

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3 

Declarer: South

Lead:  K

Board: 4

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 1 

Declarer: West

Lead:  K

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 6
 ♥ Q 8 5
 ♦ A 9 3 2
 ♣ 10 9 4

♠ K 9 8 3

♥ 7 6

♦ K Q 5

♣ A J 7 6



♠ 10 5 4
 ♥ J 10 9 2
 ♦ J 10 8 6
 ♣ 5 3

♠ Q J 2

♥ A K 4 3

♦ 7 4

♣ K Q 8 2

NORTH has 13 points but has no bid over 1♦.
 SOUTH can make a Takeout Double, so he does.

NORTH now cue-bids ♦ to show opening hand strength.

SOUTH shows his ♥ suit, NORTH doesn't like it.
 NORTH shows her ♠ suit, SOUTH doesn't like it.
 SOUTH shows his ♣ suit, NORTH likes it fine, but decides 3NT will be easier than 5♣.

West	North	East	South
1♦	Pass	Pass	Dbl
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♣
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♦ J			

Board 2

East Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 5 3
♥ 9 8 4
♦ 10 3 2
♣ A J 7 4

♠ 9 6

♥ Q 6 5

♦ J 7 5 4

♣ K 10 6 2



♠ K 8 2

♥ K J 10 2

♦ K Q 9

♣ Q 8 3

♠ A J 10 7 4

♥ A 7 3

♦ A 8 6

♣ 9 5

SOUTH would have had a great opening 1♠ bid. But when EAST opened 1♠ in front of him he was hornswaggled. He couldn't bid any other suit, he couldn't bid 1NT and he sure couldn't bid ♠s. So he must pass.

And so does everybody else pass.

*West**North**East**South*

1♠

All Pass

1♠ by East

Lead: ♣9

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 10 4
♥ K 9 6 3
♦ A 4 2
♣ A K J 9

♠ A 8 2

♥ J 5 2

♦ K 9 8 6

♣ 7 5 3



♠ 6

♥ A Q 10 8

♦ J 10 7 5

♣ Q 10 8 4

♠ K Q J 9 7 5 3

♥ 7 4

♦ Q 3

♣ 6 2

If East had passed, SOUTH would have opened with a preemptive 3♠.

She should make the same bid with the same hand AFTER the opponents open. And she makes it for the same reason, to describe her hand and to take away bidding space from the opponents.

NORTH treats it just like a Preemptive 3-bid, even though it is now called a Weak Jump Overcall. In this case, NORTH passes.

*West**North**East**South*

1♣

3♠

All Pass

3♠ by South

Lead: ♣K

Board 4

South Deals

Both Vul

♠ A J 10 8 5
♥ 6 3
♦ A J 10 8 5
♣ 3

♠ Q 4

♥ 10 9 8 2

♦ K Q 7

♣ K Q J 2



♠ K 7 2

♥ Q J 5 4

♦ 6 3

♣ 9 8 6 4

♠ 9 6 3

♥ A K 7

♦ 9 4 2

♣ A 10 7 5

WEST has 12 points, but with two 5-card suits worthy of an overcall. There isn't really a right and wrong here, but it usually works out best to overcall in the higher-ranking suit. That leaves open the possibility of bidding the second suit later.

In this Deal, after WEST overcalls 1♠, that later possibility never happens because everybody should pass.

*West**North**East**South*

1♠

All Pass

1♠ by West

Lead: ♣K

1♣